

PROJECT ZR/RIFLE: THE CIA'S ASSASSINATION NETWORK

On **February 19, 1962**, Richard Helms sent William K. Harvey a memorandum that was only four paragraphs long.

It authorized Harvey to retain a principal agent called **QJWIN**, plus “such other principal agents and sub-agents as may be required.” QJWIN would receive **\$7,200 a year**. Harvey received thousands more for operations. Expenses could be accounted for by broad category and Harvey's certification rather than the usual stack of vouchers.

Then came the sentence that should make any archivist sit up straight:

“This memorandum is to be considered in lieu of project.”

No normal project package. No sprawling paper trail. Strictly **EYES ONLY**.

[IMAGE: The February 19, 1962 Helms authorization with “in lieu of project” and “EYES ONLY” highlighted | ALT: Declassified CIA memorandum authorizing ZR/RIFLE agent activities under William Harvey.]

At first, the files beneath that authority look almost ordinary—if your definition of ordinary includes art-dealer fronts, Corsican criminals, safecrackers and men willing to force office workers to open vaults.

QJWIN, whose real name was **José Marie André Mankel**, spent much of his time locating burglars in Europe. CIA officers hid behind commercial stories about stolen industrial documents. Candidates were assessed for discretion, nerve and whether they could work without tracing the job back to the United States.

So was ZR/RIFLE simply a black-bag program?

That is what part of the record says.

The other part says the CIA was building a **standby capability to commit assassination**.

And the strangest thing is that both stories were true.

THE PROJECT THAT WASN'T A PROJECT

In 1975, the Senate's Church Committee finally put the euphemism into plain English. “[Executive Action](#)” meant a capability for removing foreign leaders, with assassination at the far end of the spectrum. The CIA gave that capability a cryptonym: **ZR/RIFLE**.

The committee found that Richard Bissell, then the Agency's Deputy Director for Plans, assigned Harvey to develop it. Harvey was not told to assemble a permanent squad in matching uniforms. The design was quieter than that.

Find people who could be used.

Keep them separated.

Research methods.

Build the machinery before anyone supplied the target.

QJWIN was the principal agent under Harvey's supervision. Richard Helms later described his value with brutal economy: if somebody needed a murder carried out, QJWIN might know a man prepared to do it.

Harvey insisted that no agent was actually recruited *for assassination* during the project's life and that no target list was drawn. The Church Committee found no indication that QJWIN himself performed a killing. Those are meaningful limits.

They do not turn ZR/RIFLE into a misunderstanding.

The committee concluded that the project assessed assassination requirements, researched techniques and developed a standby capability. Bissell called it "internal and purely preparatory." A 1967 CIA Inspector General review called it a general capability to carry out assassination when required.

That sounds like a semantic dispute until you look at how the system was built.

WHO ASKED FOR IT?

Harvey told investigators that Bissell said the **White House** had twice urged the CIA to create an executive-action capability. His notes reportedly preserved that claim. Bissell's memory was less stable. At different points he accepted Harvey's account, suggested any White House contact would likely have involved McGeorge Bundy or Walt Rostow, and said he had merely informed Bundy rather than received an order from him.

That leaves an authorization gap at the top.

The institutional approvals below it are clearer. Bissell gave Harvey the assignment. Harvey said he briefed Helms on the general concept. Helms signed the agent authorization. The CIA funded QJWIN and renewed the arrangement. None of that requires a presidential murder order.

It does expose a system built to protect senior officials from having to issue one.

The Church Committee could not establish that President Kennedy authorized ZR/RIFLE as an assassination program. It also found that vague language about "removing" or "getting rid of" foreign leaders could move down a hierarchy and acquire a more lethal meaning at each level. Officials at the top could imagine regime change. Operators lower down could prepare the means. Everyone could later testify—accurately, within his compartment—that nobody had said the forbidden word in his presence.

Plausible deniability was not just the public excuse after exposure. It shaped how the operation was communicated before exposure.

That is why the missing White House sentence does not erase the program. It identifies a feature of it: political intent could enter as pressure, urgency or desired outcome, while operational officers translated that atmosphere into capabilities leaders might never have to acknowledge.

And once a capability existed, it did not need a new organizational chart every time somebody found a target.

THE SAFECRACKER COVER WAS REAL

In November 1960, CIA officers met QJWIN in Luxembourg and briefed him for a trip into Africa. They told him the Agency wanted dependable, quick-witted people—especially Corsicans—who could be spotted and assessed for future use.

They did **not** tell him the true requirement.

The dispatch said the objective was too sensitive. QJWIN received a commercial legend, travel instructions and emergency contact procedures. Notes, phone details and a photograph were supposed to be destroyed after reading. Even the man doing the recruiting was being kept outside the final compartment.

Other cables show him moving through Italy, France and Switzerland looking for people who could break into buildings, open safes and steal documents. Some candidates were professional criminals. One asked whether he should be armed. Another was described as willing to “go to the end.”

This was real work. Embassies and intelligence services did want codebooks, ciphers and documents stolen.

But the [Church Committee’s report](#) included a devastating footnote: the other ZR/RIFLE program was genuine, **and it was also meant to provide cover for Executive Action.**

There it is.

The safecracker story was not a fake shell painted over an empty box. It generated missions, recruits, expenses and records. That made it better cover. Anyone opening the file would find evidence of burglary because burglary was actually happening.

ZR/RIFLE connects here to a method White Rabbit readers have seen before. In [Operation TWO-FOLD](#), CIA officers later spotted, assessed and quietly recruited personnel while hiding the Agency’s role behind another institution and a proprietary company. TWO-FOLD was not a continuation of ZR/RIFLE. It demonstrates the same administrative truth: **a concealed personnel system works best when its visible function is real.**

[IMAGE: Split diagram showing the genuine burglary program on one side and Executive Action on the other, joined under ZR/RIFLE | ALT: Diagram of ZR/RIFLE’s dual structure: real safecracking operations and concealed assassination capability.]

The paperwork becomes easier to understand once you stop asking which program was “the real one.”

They were nested.

HOW TO BUILD A MURDER THAT CANNOT WALK BACK TO YOU

The most revealing ZR/RIFLE material is not a poison recipe or a list of targets. It is a planning outline recovered from the project files.

A 1975 Rockefeller Commission staff memorandum described pages organized around **legal, ethical, moral and operational problems**—and above all, political nonattribution. The planner wanted one internal focal point with Deputy Director authority. Innocuous cables only. Word of mouth. No discussion in ordinary stations. No team until a job was ready, if there was ever a team at all.

The candidates should not have obvious American connections. Chains should be avoided. Operations should run person to person, using singletons. The outline considered forged and backdated records that would resemble a counterintelligence file. It even proposed preparing to blame the Soviets or Czechs if an operation blew up.

You do not need to guess what problem this architecture was solving.

It was designed to make responsibility hard to reconstruct.

The [Rockefeller staff review of the ZR/RIFLE files](#) found criminal profiles under tabs, sealed traffic instructions and financial records that depended on Harvey's certification. One personality sketch described a Beirut underworld figure with access to a pool of assassins. A slip of paper in a personal envelope carried the name **John Roselli** and two aliases.

There were also mundane receipts: hotels, long-distance calls, travel advances. That is what covert architecture looks like from the accounting desk. The horror is rarely itemized as "murder." It appears as a room, a meeting, a chartered boat and an officer certifying that the money was properly spent.

One April 1963 expense sheet charged ZR/RIFLE for Harvey's hotels and calls in the Miami area, plus **\$75 for an operational boat charter at Islamorada**. The commission staffer who reviewed it suspected Cuba-related activity but could not resolve the purpose.

An unexplained boat is not a solved plot.

It is an open door.

[IMAGE: Map linking Luxembourg, Frankfurt, Leopoldville, Dakar, Rome and Miami with dated QJWIN/Harvey movements | ALT: Map of the European, African and Florida locations appearing in the ZR/RIFLE record.]

THE CONGO FILE THAT WILL NOT SIT STILL

QJWIN was originally recruited for what CIA financial memoranda called a **one-shot mission** in the Belgian Congo. He would be paid at a high monthly rate because the assignment involved "great personal risk." Harvey later wrote that the specific, highly sensitive purpose had been completed.

What purpose?

The surviving records do not say.

The timing is impossible to ignore. The CIA was then involved in a separate plot against Congolese prime minister **Patrice Lumumba**. Sidney Gottlieb carried poison to Leopoldville. The station never used it, and Lumumba was ultimately killed by Congolese and Katangan enemies after transfer into their custody. The historical record proves an American assassination effort; it does not prove QJWIN was its instrument.

Still, the QJWIN file is full of pressure marks from whatever was removed. He was dispatched quickly. His real requirement was withheld. Headquarters wanted him kept clean of side jobs. A later CIA history said he had been recruited for a special Congo operation connected to Justin O'Donnell, the officer who surveyed the assassination proposal and wanted out.

Then another asset appears: **WIROGUE**.

WIROGUE's 199-page file mostly concerns aircraft, instructors, cover documents and his erratic role around the Congolese air force. Buried in that administrative mass is a November 1961 station assessment. He was too disorganized to be a good reporting agent, it said, but could be useful when action was required. His mind lent itself to "nefarious and extra-legal activities," preferably of an action type.

That is a chilling personnel evaluation.

It is not a kill order.

The Congo connection remains the strongest unresolved ZR/RIFLE rabbit hole because the surrounding facts are specific while the final edge is missing. QJWIN and WIROGUE were in the right theater. Both were assessed for deniable action. The Agency was pursuing Lumumba's removal. But proximity cannot supply the missing tasking document.

An extreme theory either earns its final step here or loses it.

For now, it loses it.

THEN HARVEY GOT A LIVE TARGET PROGRAM

ZR/RIFLE stopped being merely a contingency question when Harvey took over the Agency's organized-crime channel against Fidel Castro.

The CIA had already reached into the Mafia through Robert Maheu, John Roselli, Sam Giancana and Santos Trafficante. Poison capsules had been prepared. Cuban intermediaries were sought. The plots moved through cutouts chosen precisely because they gave officials room to deny what they had set in motion.

In November 1961, Bissell instructed Harvey to take over the Roselli contact. The Church Committee concluded that after Harvey assumed responsibility for the Castro operation, he ran it as one aspect of ZR/RIFLE.

At nearly the same moment, the Kennedy administration launched Operation MONGOOSE. The State Department's official [Operation MONGOOSE chronology](#) identifies Harvey as the head of Task Force W, the CIA unit implementing the program. By mid-1962, hundreds of CIA personnel were working on intelligence, sabotage, propaganda, resistance networks and regime-change planning against Cuba.

The same man now held two things:

- a compartment built to research and assemble deniable executive action;
- a massive covert program aimed at overthrowing a government whose leader the CIA was already trying to kill.

[IMAGE: Timeline from Bissell's assignment to Helms's authorization, Harvey's Roselli takeover and Task Force W | ALT: Timeline showing the convergence of ZR/RIFLE, Mafia contacts and Operation MONGOOSE under William Harvey.]

The [official MONGOOSE records](#) describe a 477-person CIA effort by July 1962. They do not label every sabotage proposal an assassination plan. They do show the operational scale that surrounded Harvey while the smaller ZR/RIFLE compartment remained protected by restricted traffic and special accounting.

The capability and the target program had become “wedded,” as later testimony put it.

Most MONGOOSE officers had no need to know about murder planning. Compartmentation existed to keep it that way.

Readers of [The MK-Ultra Files](#) will recognize Sidney Gottlieb's appearance at the technical edge of the story. Readers of [Operation Gladio](#) will recognize the attraction of deniable outsiders and insulated chains. The callback is about method, not a claim that these programs were one continuous organization.

ZR/RIFLE had now crossed the line that matters: the CIA did not merely imagine a capability in the abstract. Its manager applied the compartment to an actual campaign involving a real foreign leader and real underworld intermediaries.

DID THE GUN TURN AROUND?

This is where the story usually races to Dallas.

The supplied books make that leap directly. In *Bond of Secrecy*, Saint John Hunt recounts his father E. Howard Hunt's late claim that he had been a “benchwarmer” in a plot against Kennedy. Hunt named anti-Castro operatives and put Harvey near the center of the design. Claudia Furiati's *ZR Rifle* argues that the machinery built against Castro was redirected against the American president.

These accounts are not disposable. They are author-supplied testimony, and they point toward real people, real programs and real hostilities.

They are also not enough.

Hunt gave changing versions over the years. His late account arrived through family tapes and notes, after decades of public accusation. Marita Lorenz's related claims were dramatic, contested and never repaired by a contemporaneous ZR/RIFLE order, payment trail or operational record.

The theory has a plausible mechanism. It has motive candidates. It has overlapping personnel. It has a government that undeniably concealed assassination plotting.

What it does not have is the decisive bridge.

No recovered ZR/RIFLE target list names Kennedy. No authenticated tasking sends QJWIN, Roselli or a Harvey-controlled singleton to Dallas. No financial record closes the chain. The capability to do something is not proof that it was done in one particular case.

So the maximum thesis fails.

But something else survives—and it may be more important than another unsupported solution to Dallas.

THE COVER-UP WE CAN ACTUALLY PROVE

The CIA did not tell the Warren Commission about its plots to assassinate Castro.

Senior FBI officials knew about earlier underworld plots. Senior CIA officers knew far more. The working investigators and agency liaisons who dealt with the Commission were kept outside those compartments. Allen Dulles, the former CIA director who sat on the Commission, presumably knew about plots from his tenure, but the record supplied to the inquiry did not disclose them.

The Senate's final [investigation of intelligence-agency performance](#) was careful: it did not claim it had proven a conspiracy to kill Kennedy.

It did conclude that the investigation was deficient.

CIA personnel responsible for examining the assassination later testified that knowledge of the Castro plots would have been a vital factor in shaping their work. The Warren Commission received none of it. Investigators could not properly judge retaliation, exile networks, organized-crime contacts or the significance of Oswald's Cuba-related activity because the government had withheld part of the operating environment.

[IMAGE: Flowchart showing senior CIA knowledge stopping above Warren Commission investigators | ALT: Diagram of how CIA assassination-plot information was withheld from the Warren Commission and working investigators.]

That distinction is everything.

The proven cover-up is not proof that CIA killed Kennedy. It is proof that the Agency concealed information materially relevant to deciding whether its own operations, assets or enemies intersected the crime.

In [USAID & The CIA: The Network](#), we followed a later system by asking where access had been built into it, not by waiting for a memo announcing total control. ZR/RIFLE requires the same discipline. Its power lay in the seams: one officer knew the purpose, another handled the asset, a station saw an innocent cable, a finance desk saw a certified expense and the candidate saw only his commercial legend.

When investigators later searched for a conspiracy, that design worked against them.

There was no single file labeled **THE THING YOU NEED TO KNOW ABOUT DALLAS**.

There were compartments.

WHAT ZR/RIFLE REALLY BUILT

ZR/RIFLE was not a standing hit squad waiting in a government basement.

It was more useful than that.

It was a method for locating disposable talent, separating every participant from the final sponsor, moving money without detailed vouchers, communicating through harmless traffic, manufacturing cover records and activating a team only when a target appeared.

The burglary program was real. That made the cover durable.

The assassination capability was real. That made the cover necessary.

The Castro application was real. That made the capability more than a thought experiment.

And the withholding from the Warren Commission was real. That made an already difficult murder investigation structurally incomplete.

What remains unproven is that ZR/RIFLE killed John Kennedy. We should not weaken the documented case by pretending the missing edge exists.

The stronger historical finding is sitting in the paperwork: American officials created a deniable machinery for political murder, connected it to criminal intermediaries and then allowed the country's most consequential assassination inquiry to proceed without that knowledge.

The [USAID–CIA handoff investigation](#) showed how a function can outlive the office that once housed it. ZR/RIFLE leaves a similar question, but not yet an answer. In June 1963, Harvey wrote that the project's ZR/RIFLE aspects had been terminated—except for one precautionary “**lifeline**.” QJWIN's contract ended the following year.

What was the lifeline?

And what exactly had QJWIN completed in the Congo before the project had a public name?

[IMAGE: Closing image of a redacted project folder with a single line extending to an unlabeled file marked “lifeline” | ALT: Conceptual illustration of ZR/RIFLE's unresolved residual lifeline after formal termination.]

Those are not invitations to invent an answer.

They are the next records to find.

FAQ

What was Project ZR/RIFLE?

ZR/RIFLE was a CIA cryptonym used for a genuine burglary and criminal-recruitment program and for a compartmented Executive Action capability that included assassination. The nonlethal program also supplied cover for the more sensitive mission.

Who was QJWIN?

QJWIN was José Marie André Mankel, a CIA principal agent used to spot and assess burglars, safecrackers and underworld candidates in Europe. Records also place him on a one-shot, high-risk Congo mission whose precise purpose remains unresolved.

Did ZR/RIFLE try to assassinate Fidel Castro?

The Church Committee found that William Harvey took over the organized-crime contact against Castro and ran the Castro operation as an aspect of ZR/RIFLE. QJWIN himself was not shown to have participated in an actual Castro attempt.

Did ZR/RIFLE assassinate President Kennedy?

No recovered record proves that. Late testimony and network overlap make the question understandable, but no authenticated target order, payment trail or operational tasking connects ZR/RIFLE to Dallas.

What did the CIA hide from the Warren Commission?

The CIA did not disclose its plots to assassinate Castro, including operations involving underworld figures and a high-level Cuban official. Senate investigators later concluded that this omission impaired the intelligence agencies' and Warren Commission's work.

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- [Operation TWO-FOLD: The CIA Inside Federal Drug Enforcement](#)
- [Operation Gladio: The Hidden History of NATO's Secret Armies](#)
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